direct actions brought by natural or legal persons, and by the Civil Service Tribunal which hears cases brought by employees of the EU's institutions.

5. *Court of Auditors:* The European Court of Auditors, despite its name, has no judicial powers. The Court provides an audit report for each financial year to the Council and the Parliament. The Parliament uses this to decide whether to approve the Commission's handling of the budget. The Court also gives opinions and proposals on the financial legislation and anti-fraud actions.

It is composed of one member from each state appointed by the Council, every six years. Every three years one of them is elected to be the President of the Court.

6. *European Economic and Social Committee (EESC):* It was established in 1957. It is a consultative assembly composed of employers, employees and representatives of various industries and work sectors. The committee advises on economic and social policies (principally, relations between workers and employers). It has 344 members, appointed by the Council, for four-year terms. Members of the EESC are divided into three groups of equal number: employers employees and a third group of various other changing interests such as farmers, consumer groups, professional associations, and so on. The members are appointed by the Council following the nominations made by the governments of the respective member states. However, once appointed, the members are completely independent of their governments. The EESC shares the Delors Building in Brussels as its seat, with the Committee of the Regions.

Among the other prominent EU institutions are the Committee of the Regions, European Central Bank, the European Investment Bank and the European Investment Fund.

The present challenges before EU are legitimacy gap, 'widening' and 'deepening', and the future of Common Foreign Security Policy (CFSP). As scholars have pointed out "the main challenge for the EU is the current impossibility of creating a true parliamentary basis of democracy". Although the European Parliament exists, it is regarded as the weakest of the main policy-making institutions. The Maastricht